

How To Teach Your Child Your Mother Tongue

1. Speak to your child in only your mother tongue.
2. Speak to your child in ways that they cannot understand.
3. Watch their face go blank in confusion.
4. Lament to yourself (and to your child) about how pitiful it is that they cannot speak your mother tongue. Make sure to perfect your facial expressions for this step, to look extra disappointed.
5. See them roll their eyes at you, then storm upstairs and slam their bedroom door.
6. Feel the frustration boiling in the pit of your stomach, rising up your throat.
7. Gag because the acidity reminds you of your childhood, when you could only afford to eat sweet potatoes.
8. Taste the metallic disgust in your mouth.
9. Think that your child would not have survived what you survived.
10. Let that thought pass.
11. Feel guilty that it came.
12. Look in the mirror and see your cheeks, flushed red from anger.
13. Glance at the mirror frame and observe its delicate flowery design.
14. Feel a pang in your heart as you remember that this was the one piece of home that you brought over with you to your new world.
15. Notice your mother's wrinkles and forehead creases imprinted on your own face.
16. Search for something of yourself that is only yours.
17. Find nothing. Find everything.
18. Remember that you barely spoke with your mother as a child, because she was outside all day, working the land and making trades just to put food on the table.
19. Remember that you cannot remember the sound of your mother's voice.
20. Miss your mother's touch. The bones close to the surface. The tough calluses from decades of toil.
21. Realize that you have been weeping.
22. Stand there for a moment longer than you mean to.
23. Decide, without deciding, to do something.
24. Head to the kitchen for a napkin.
25. Forget what you meant to do in the kitchen.
26. Grab an apple and the sweetest looking asian pear from the counter.
27. Grab a knife, still scented from dicing garlic.
28. Cut the fruit carefully, and chew the remaining flesh off the pits.
29. Plate the small pieces in a swirl, then lay a fork on top.
30. Walk upstairs, offering in hand.
31. Knock on their door.
32. Pray for a response.
33. Hear silence.
34. Notice your eyes welling up again.
35. Speak to your child in your mother tongue: "I cut some fruit for you. I'll leave it outside."